Why do young Americans support redistribution?

Survey evidence on a widening U.S. age gap

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October 19, 2026

Formative-years growth and redistribution in the US

Table 1: Prolific 2025: support for redistribution on home-state formative-years income growth

Dependent Variables:	Reduce income differences				More progressive taxes	Support redistributive proposal
Spec.:	0–20	18–25	0–20, +age	0–20, +coh.		0–20
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Variables						
Formative growth, ages 0–20	-0.281***		0.082	0.028	-0.143***	-0.152***
	(0.045)		(0.059)	(0.071)	(0.043)	(0.042)
Formative growth, ages 18–25		-0.002				
		(0.026)				
Age			-0.019**			
			(0.009)			
Age^2			4.21×10^{-5}			
			(0.0001)			
Fixed-effects						
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)				Yes		
Fit statistics						
Observations	2,231	1,802	2,231	2,231	2,231	2,231
R^2	0.03980	0.02467	0.07179	0.10113	0.02824	0.02554

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.150	–	–	–	−0.077	−0.081
as % of the young–old gap	57%	–	–	–	55%	61%

Formative-years growth and redistribution: movers only

Table 2: Prolific 2025, movers only (home state $\neq$ current state): support for redistribution on home-state formative growth, with and without current-state FE

Dependent Variable:	Reduce income differences			
Current-state FE:	No	Yes	No	Yes
Age controls:	No		Yes	
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variables				
Formative growth, ages 0–20	-0.338***	-0.312***	0.032	0.071
	(0.071)	(0.079)	(0.108)	(0.117)
Age			-0.030	-0.024
			(0.021)	(0.022)
Age^2			0.0002	9.08×10^{-5}
			(0.0002)	(0.0003)
Fixed-effects				
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Current state		Yes		Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	673	672	673	672
R^2	0.07756	0.17744	0.10692	0.20350

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.198	−0.183	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	70%	64%	–	–

Absolute mobility and redistribution in the US

Table 3: Prolific 2025: support for redistribution on home-state absolute mobility

Dependent Variables:	Reduce income differences			More progressive taxes	Support redistributive proposal
Spec.:	home FE	+age	+coh.		home FE
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Variables					
Absolute mobility (SD)	-0.113***	-0.077	-0.303*	-0.031	-0.060**
	(0.034)	(0.091)	(0.164)	(0.044)	(0.028)
Age		-0.036			
		(0.028)			
Age^2		0.0003			
		(0.0002)			
Fixed-effects					
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)			Yes		
Fit statistics					
Observations	998	998	998	998	998
R^2	0.04822	0.04990	0.09092	0.04996	0.04385

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.113	–	–	–	−0.060
as % of the young–old gap	43%	–	–	–	45%

Formative-years growth relative to the nation

Table 4: Prolific 2025: support for redistribution on state−national formative growth

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution			
Spec.:	0–20	18–25	0–20, +age	0–20, +coh.
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variables				
State−national growth, ages 0–20	0.021		0.036	0.028
	(0.174)		(0.073)	(0.071)
State−national growth, ages 18–25		-0.036		
		(0.051)		
Age			-0.022**	
			(0.009)	
Age^2			9.05×10^{-5}	
			(9.97×10^{-5})	
Fixed-effects				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)				Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	2,231	1,802	2,231	2,231
R^2	0.01985	0.02504	0.07118	0.10113

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size: no coefficient significant at 5%.

Absolute mobility relative to the nation

Table 5: Prolific 2025: support for redistribution on state−national absolute mobility

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution		
Spec.:	home FE	+age	+coh.
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)
Variables			
State−national abs. mobility (SD)	-0.124**	-0.025	-0.126*
	(0.047)	(0.064)	(0.068)
Age		-0.027	
		(0.032)	
Age^2		0.0002	
		(0.0003)	
Fixed-effects			
State	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)			Yes
Fit statistics			
Observations	998	998	998
R^2	0.04667	0.04943	0.09092

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.124	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	39%	–	–

Inequality grown up with and redistribution

Table 6: Prolific 2025: support for redistribution on the top-10% income share grown up with

Dependent Variable:	concern			
Model:	Top10 avg (1)	Top10 change (2)	avg − nat (3)	change − nat (4)
Variables				
Top-10% share, formative average (SD)	0.265***			
	(0.023)			
Top-10% share, formative change (SD)		0.091***		
		(0.029)		
Formative average − national (SD)			-0.041	
			(0.133)	
Formative change − national (SD)				-0.013
				(0.043)
Fixed-effects				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	2,078	2,078	2,078	2,078
R^2	0.07168	0.02750	0.02144	0.02121

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	+0.265	+0.091	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	97%	20%	–	–

Formative-years growth and zero-sum beliefs

Table 7: Prolific 2025: zero-sum beliefs on home-state formative-years income growth

Dependent Variables:	Rich gain at others' expense				CEO pay at workers' expense	DEI: opportunity trade-off
Spec.:	0–20	18–25	0–20, +age	0–20, +coh.	0–20	
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Variables						
Formative growth, ages 0–20	-0.283***		0.107	0.146**	-0.089*	0.188***
	(0.058)		(0.074)	(0.070)	(0.046)	(0.052)
Formative growth, ages 18–25		0.051				
		(0.031)				
Age			-0.017			
			(0.010)			
Age^2			-1.83×10^{-6}			
			(0.0001)			
Fixed-effects						
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)				Yes		
Fit statistics						
Observations	2,219	1,790	2,219	2,219	2,206	2,207
R^2	0.03791	0.02769	0.07300	0.09288	0.02284	0.03086

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.151	–	–	+0.078	–	+0.100
as % of the young–old gap	54%	–	–	-28%	–	75%

Absolute mobility and zero-sum beliefs

Table 8: Prolific 2025: zero-sum beliefs on home-state absolute mobility

Dependent Variables:	Rich gain at others' expense			CEO pay at workers' expense	DEI: opportunity trade-off
Spec.:	home FE	+age	+coh.	home FE	
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Variables					
Absolute mobility (SD)	-0.146***	-0.025	-0.076	-0.081**	0.006
	(0.039)	(0.082)	(0.211)	(0.031)	(0.027)
Age		-0.018			
		(0.023)			
Age^2		6.06×10^{-5}			
		(0.0002)			
Fixed-effects					
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)			Yes		
Fit statistics					
Observations	995	995	995	988	992
R^2	0.06725	0.07008	0.09496	0.05722	0.05653

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.146	–	–	−0.080	–
as % of the young–old gap	52%	–	–	108%	–

International Evidence

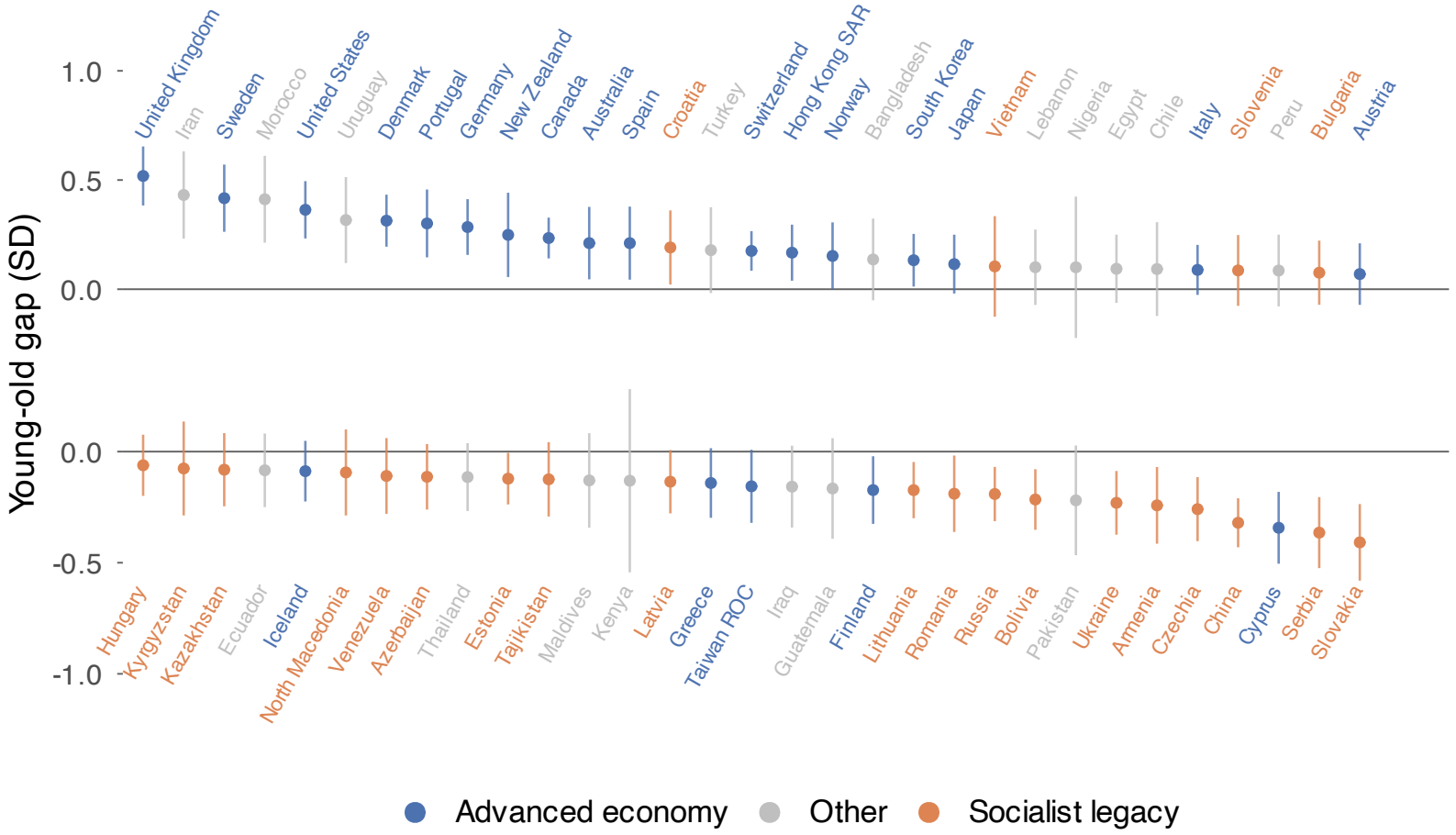


Figure 1: Age gap in redistributive preferences in WVS/EVS wave 2017–2022, countries grouped by institutional history

Zero-sum beliefs and the age gradient across countries

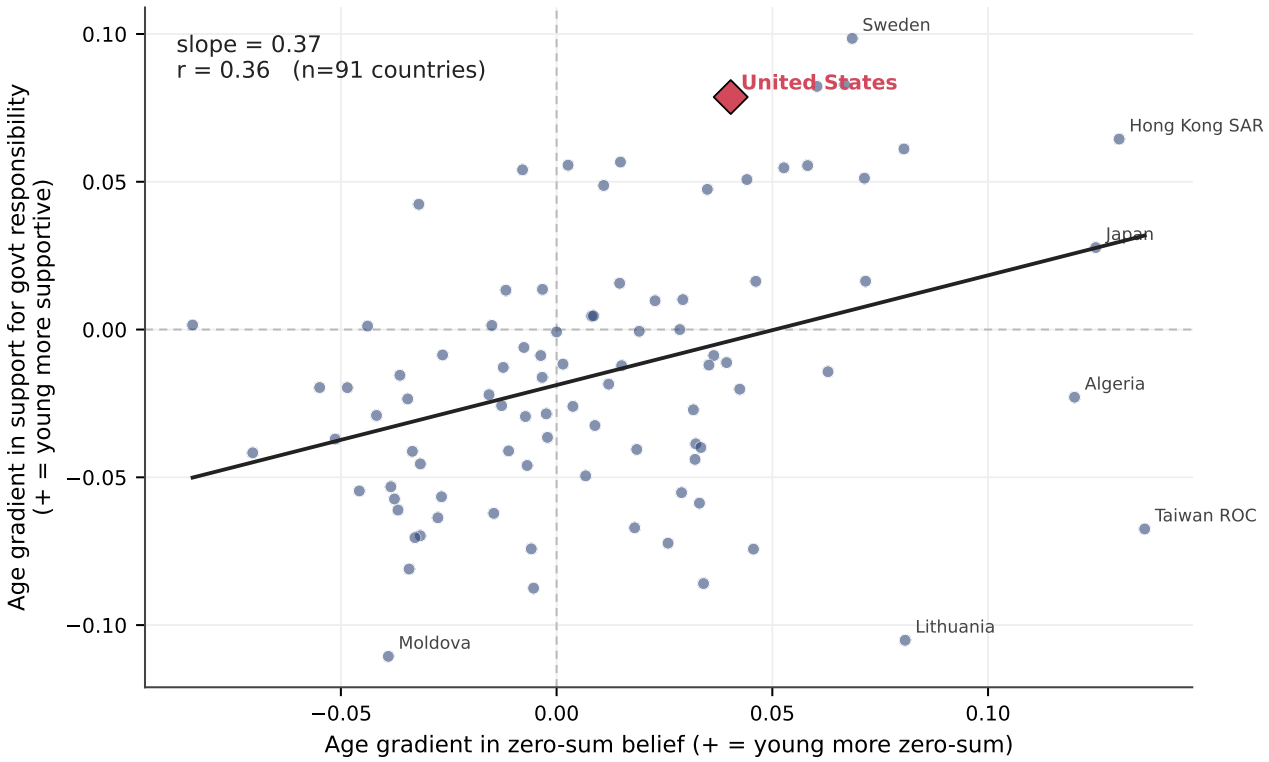


Figure 2: Age gradient in support for government responsibility (E037) vs. age gradient in zero-sum belief (E041), most recent WVS wave per country

WVS items, 1–10 scales. Government responsibility (E037): 1 = "People should take more responsibility" … 10 = "The government should take more responsibility".
Zero-sum (E041): 1 = "People can only get rich at the expense of others" … 10 = "Wealth can grow so there's enough for everyone".

Zero-sum beliefs and redistribution within countries

Table 9: Individual-level WVS: redistribution on zero-sum belief

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
A. Incomes should be made more equal (E035)				
Zero-sum belief (E041)	0.117***	0.118***	0.107***	0.108***
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.008)	(0.008)
Within R^2	0.014	0.015	0.012	0.013
Observations	236,885	236,885	236,885	236,885
B. Government should take more responsibility (E037)				
Zero-sum belief (E041)	0.075***	0.075***	0.068***	0.069***
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.009)	(0.009)
Within R^2	0.006	0.006	0.005	0.005
Observations	238,268	238,268	238,268	238,268
Country FE	Yes	Yes		
Country × wave FE			Yes	Yes
Age control		Yes		Yes
Countries	92	92	92	92

WVS waves carrying E041 (1990–2014), ages 18–79, weighted, SEs clustered by country. Items z-scored over the estimation sample (SD of the outcome per 1 SD of zero-sum); age control is age in decades. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Items on a 1–10 scale:

- E035: 1 = "Incomes should be made more equal" … 10 = "We need larger income differences as incentives" (coded + = pro-equality).
- E037: 1 = "People should take more responsibility" … 10 = "The government should take more responsibility" (coded + = pro-government).
- E041: 1 = "People can only get rich at the expense of others" … 10 = "Wealth can grow so there's enough for everyone" (coded + = zero-sum).

The widening age gradient in the US

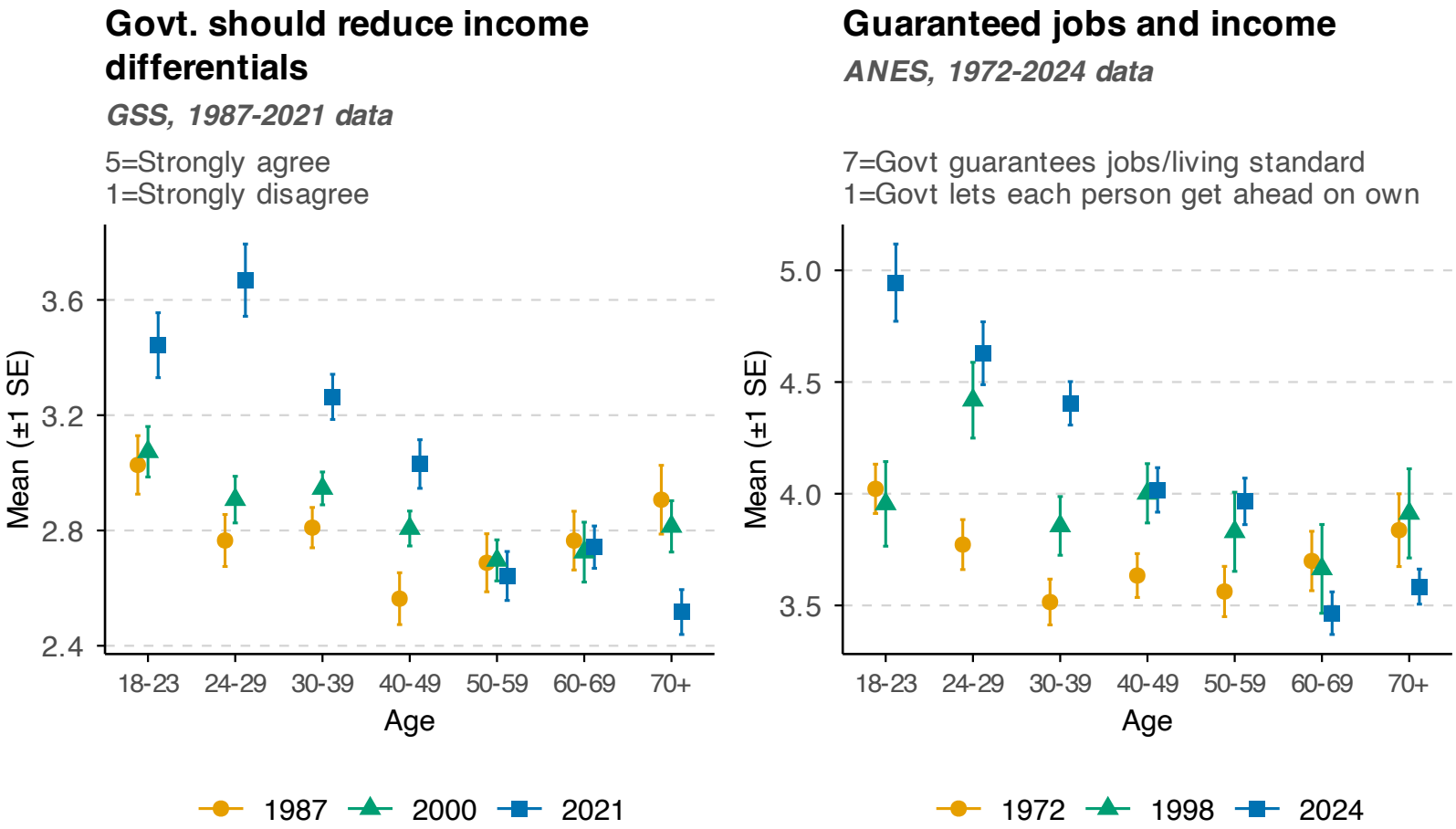


Figure 3: Age gradient in support for redistribution by survey year: GSS GOVEQINC (left) and ANES VCF0809 (right)

Zero-sum and attribution beliefs over time

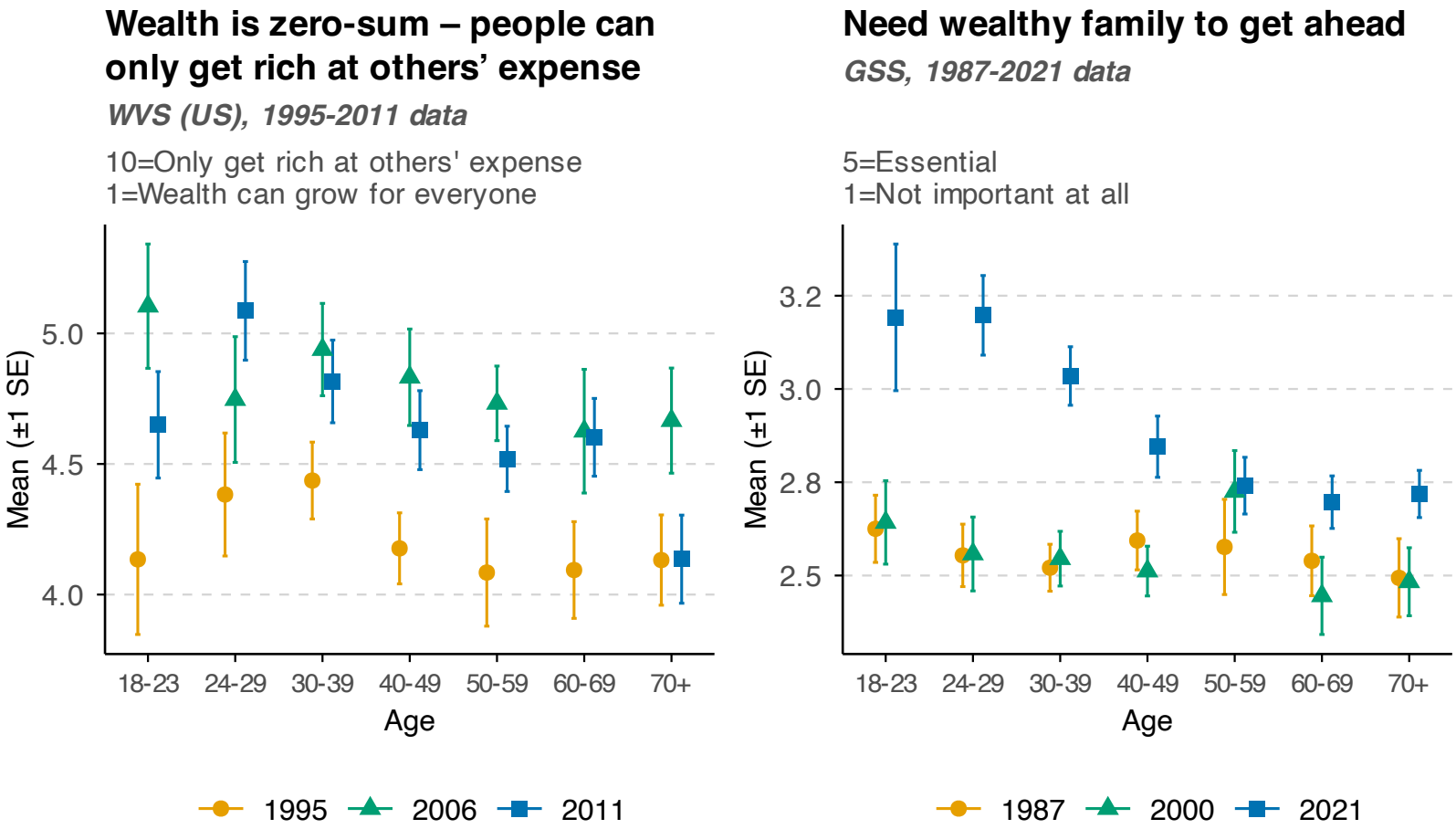


Figure 4: Age gradient in beliefs by survey year: WVS (US) E041 zero-sum wealth (left) and GSS OPWLTH need a wealthy family (right)

Redistribution and belief gaps over time

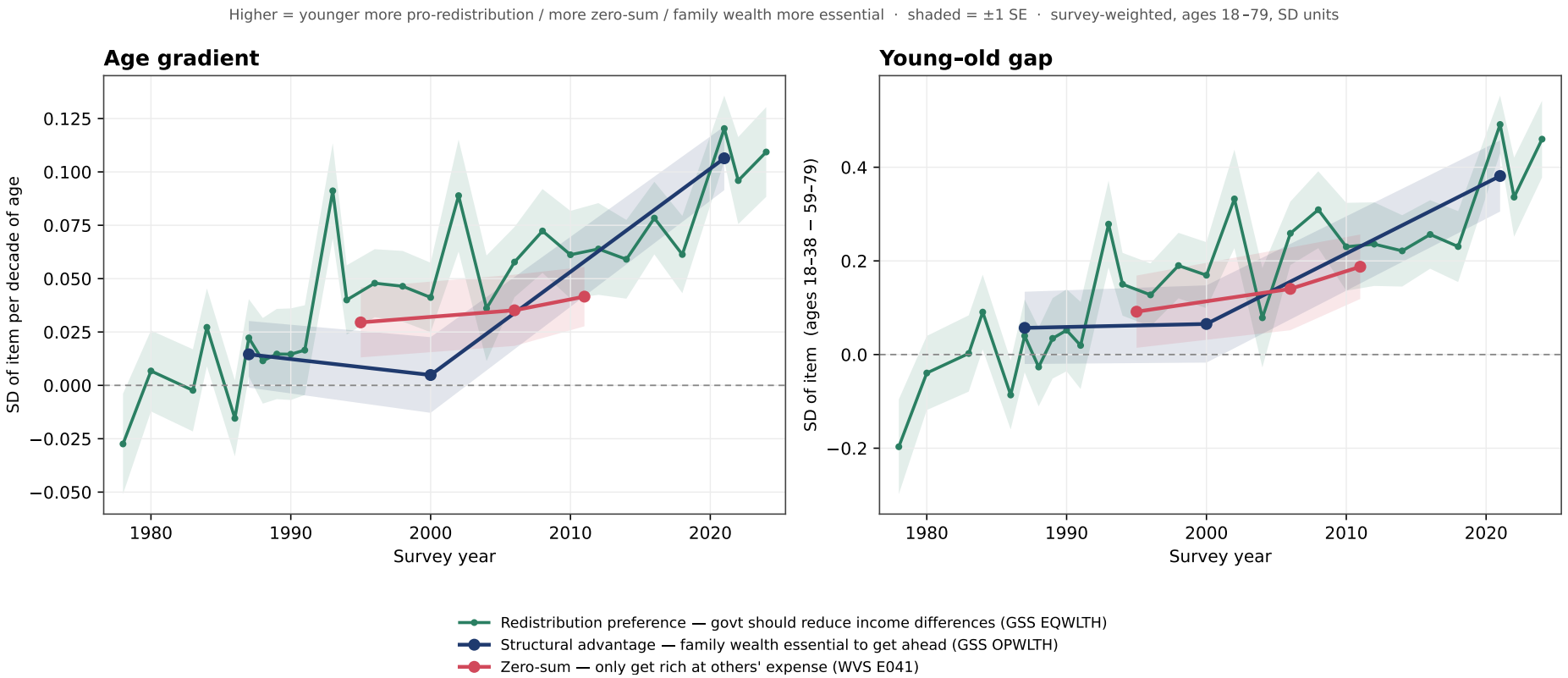


Figure 5: Young–old gap over time in redistribution preference (GSS EQWLTH) vs. zero-sum (WVS E041) and structural-advantage (GSS OPWLTH) beliefs, common SD units: age gradient (left) and 3-bin gap (right)

Inequality, growth, housing and the age gradient

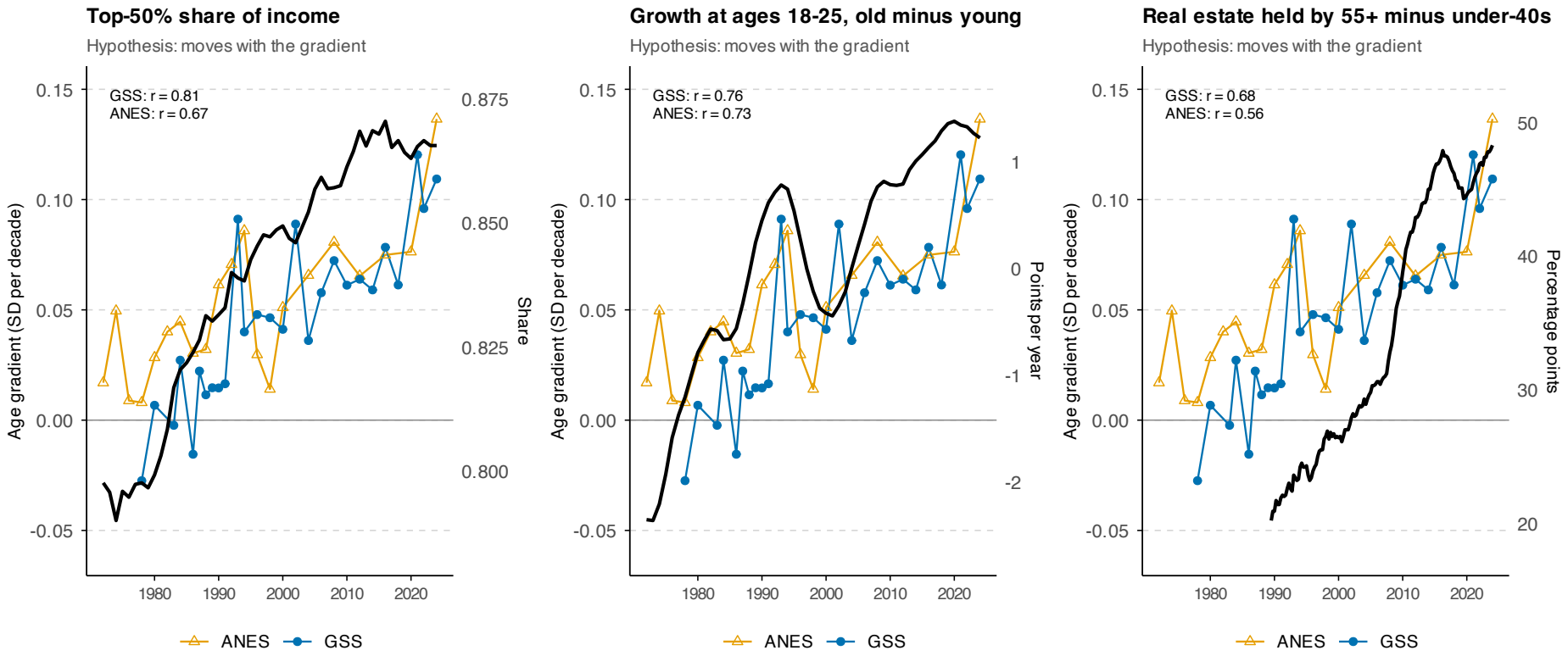
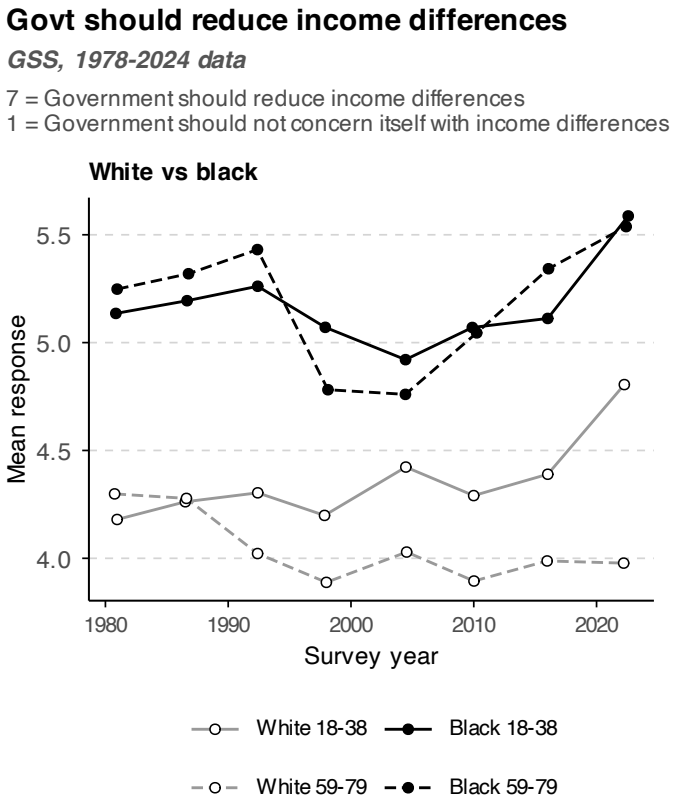


Figure 6: Age gradient in support for redistribution (GSS, ANES) vs. three US series, with correlations over survey years

Real estate: share of US household real estate held by households aged 55 and over minus the share held by those under 40, in percentage points (Federal Reserve Distributional Financial Accounts, quarterly from 1989). *r* uses its annual mean.

The age gradient by race



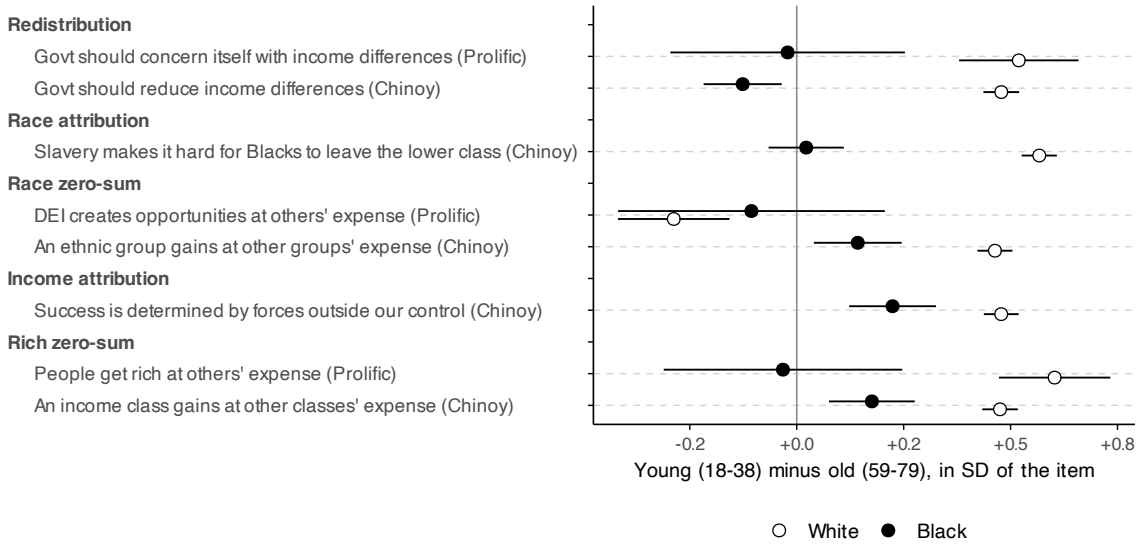


Figure 7: Left: GSS support for reducing income differences, white vs Black, ages 18–38 (solid) and 59–79 (dashed), six-year eras. Right: young–old gap (18–38 minus 59–79, SD) among white and Black respondents, Prolific and Chinoy items, 95% intervals

Formative growth and the gap across ANES states

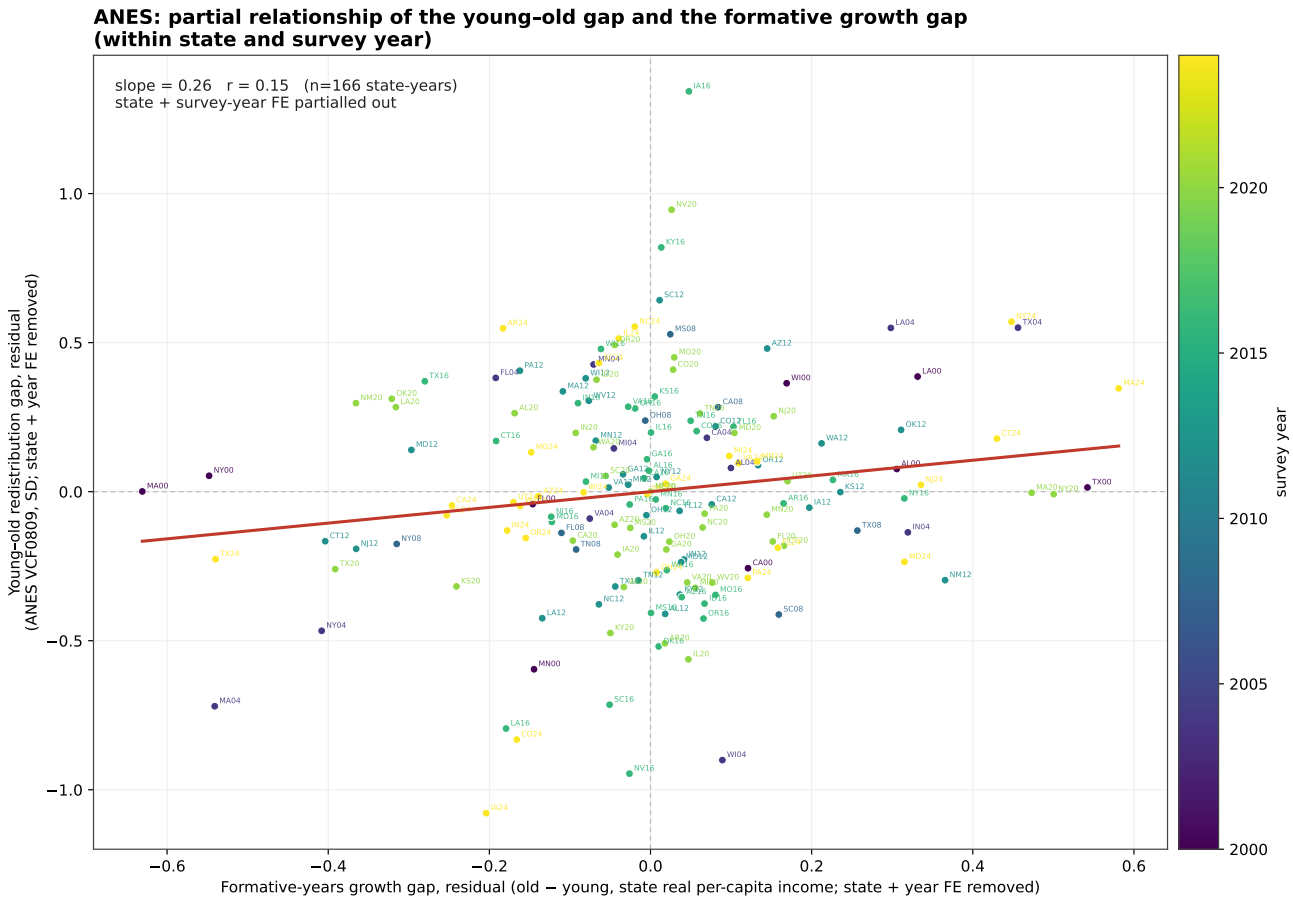


Figure 8: ANES state × year: young–old redistribution gap vs. formative-years growth gap, net of state and year FE

Formative-years growth and redistribution: ANES

Table 10: ANES: support for redistribution on own-state formative-years growth

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution (VCF0809)			
Model:	0–20 (1)	18–25 (2)	0–20, +age (3)	0–20, +cohort FE (4)
Variables				
Own-state formative growth, ages 0–20	-0.090***		0.013	0.016
	(0.012)		(0.016)	(0.021)
Own-state formative growth, ages 18–25		-0.017***		
		(0.004)		
Age			-0.024***	
			(0.003)	
Age^2			0.0002***	
			(3.4×10^{-5})	
Fixed-effects				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)				Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	36,101	40,784	36,101	36,101
R^2	0.02238	0.01688	0.03462	0.03816
Within R^2	0.00473	0.00073	0.01719	3.44×10^{-5}

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.081	−0.028	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	33%	9%	–	–

Absolute mobility and redistribution: ANES

Table 11: ANES: support for redistribution on own-state absolute mobility

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution (VCF0809)		
Model:	state+yr (1)	+age (2)	+cohort FE (3)
Variables			
Own-state absolute mobility (SD)	-0.095***	-0.003	-0.012
	(0.008)	(0.016)	(0.063)
Age		-0.024***	
		(0.004)	
Age^2		0.0002***	
		(4.11×10^{-5})	
Fixed-effects			
State	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)			Yes
Fit statistics			
Observations	30,252	30,252	30,252
R^2	0.02219	0.02505	0.02650
Within R^2	0.00715	0.01006	3.29×10^{-6}

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.095	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	45%	–	–

Formative-years growth relative to the nation: ANES

Table 12: ANES: support for redistribution on state−national formative growth

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution			
Spec.:	0–20	18–25	0–20, +age	0–20, +coh.
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variables				
State−national growth, ages 0–20	-0.011		0.019	0.016
	(0.040)		(0.024)	(0.021)
State−national growth, ages 18–25		0.009		
		(0.017)		
Age			-0.023***	
			(0.003)	
Age^2			0.0002***	
			(3.42×10^{-5})	
Fixed-effects				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)				Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	36,101	40,784	36,101	36,101
R^2	0.01775	0.01620	0.03461	0.03816

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size: no coefficient significant at 5%.

Absolute mobility relative to the nation: ANES

Table 13: ANES: support for redistribution on state−national absolute mobility

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution		
Spec.:	state+yr	+age	+coh.
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)
Variables			
State−national abs. mobility (SD)	-0.060***	0.010	-0.004
	(0.011)	(0.013)	(0.019)
Age		-0.024***	
		(0.004)	
Age^2		0.0002***	
		(4.08×10^{-5})	
Fixed-effects			
State	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)			Yes
Fit statistics			
Observations	30,252	30,252	30,252
R^2	0.01746	0.02509	0.02650

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.061	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	18%	–	–

Inequality grown up with and redistribution: ANES

Table 14: ANES: support for redistribution on the top-10% income share grown up with

Dependent Variable:	Y			
Model:	Top10 avg (1)	Top10 change (2)	avg — nat (3)	change — nat (4)
Variables				
Top-10% share, formative average (SD)	0.075***			
	(0.011)			
Top-10% share, formative change (SD)		0.079***		
		(0.008)		
Formative average — national (SD)			0.024	
			(0.023)	
Formative change — national (SD)				-0.012
				(0.010)
Fixed-effects				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	39,917	39,917	39,917	39,917
R^2	0.02235	0.02252	0.01783	0.01769

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	+0.080	+0.080	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	16%	35%	–	–

Perceived conflict between young and old

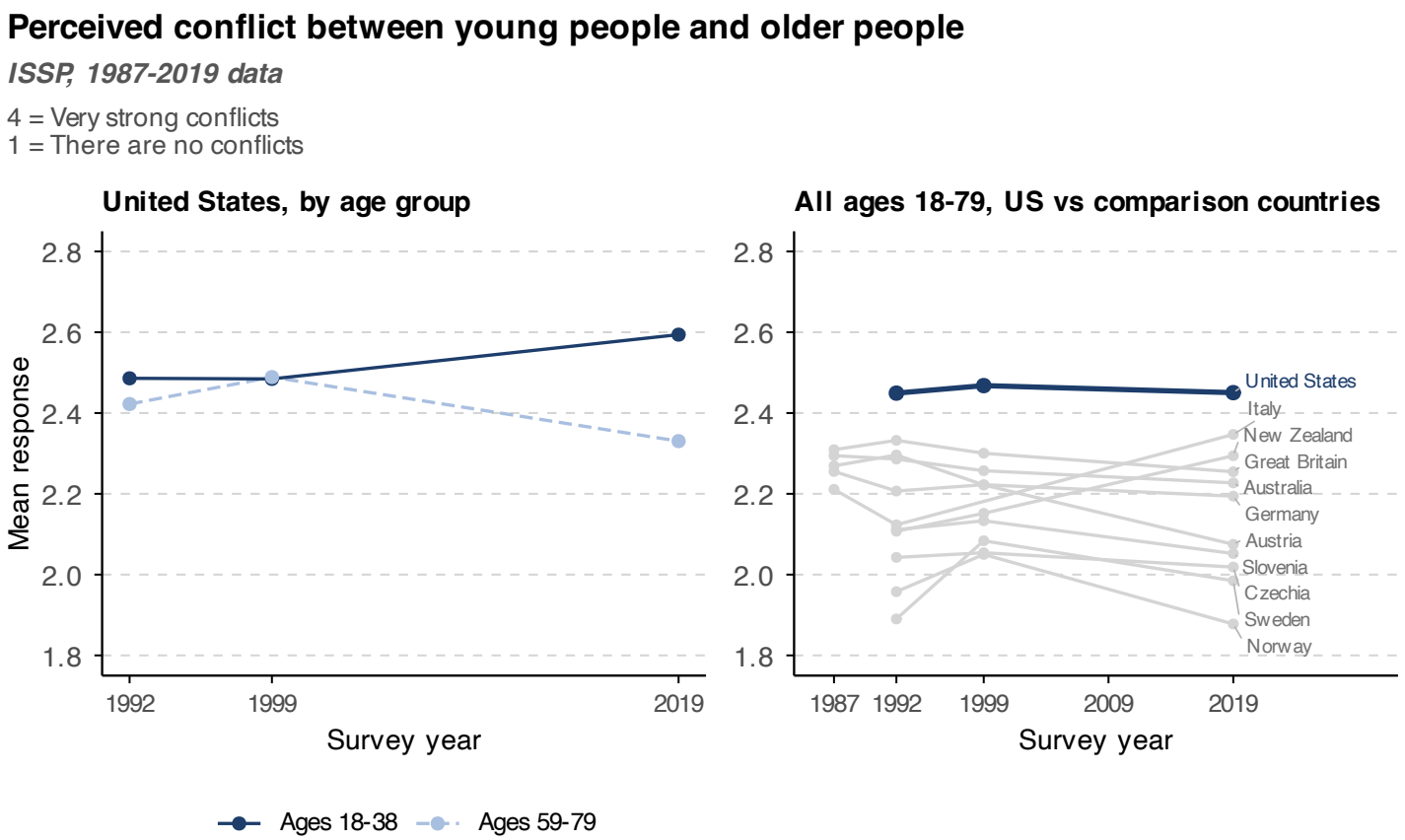


Figure 9: Perceived conflict between young and older people (ISSP Social Inequality), mean on the 4-point scale (4 = very strong). Left: US, ages 18–38 and 59–79. Right: ages 18–79, US vs. rich democracies

Social Security

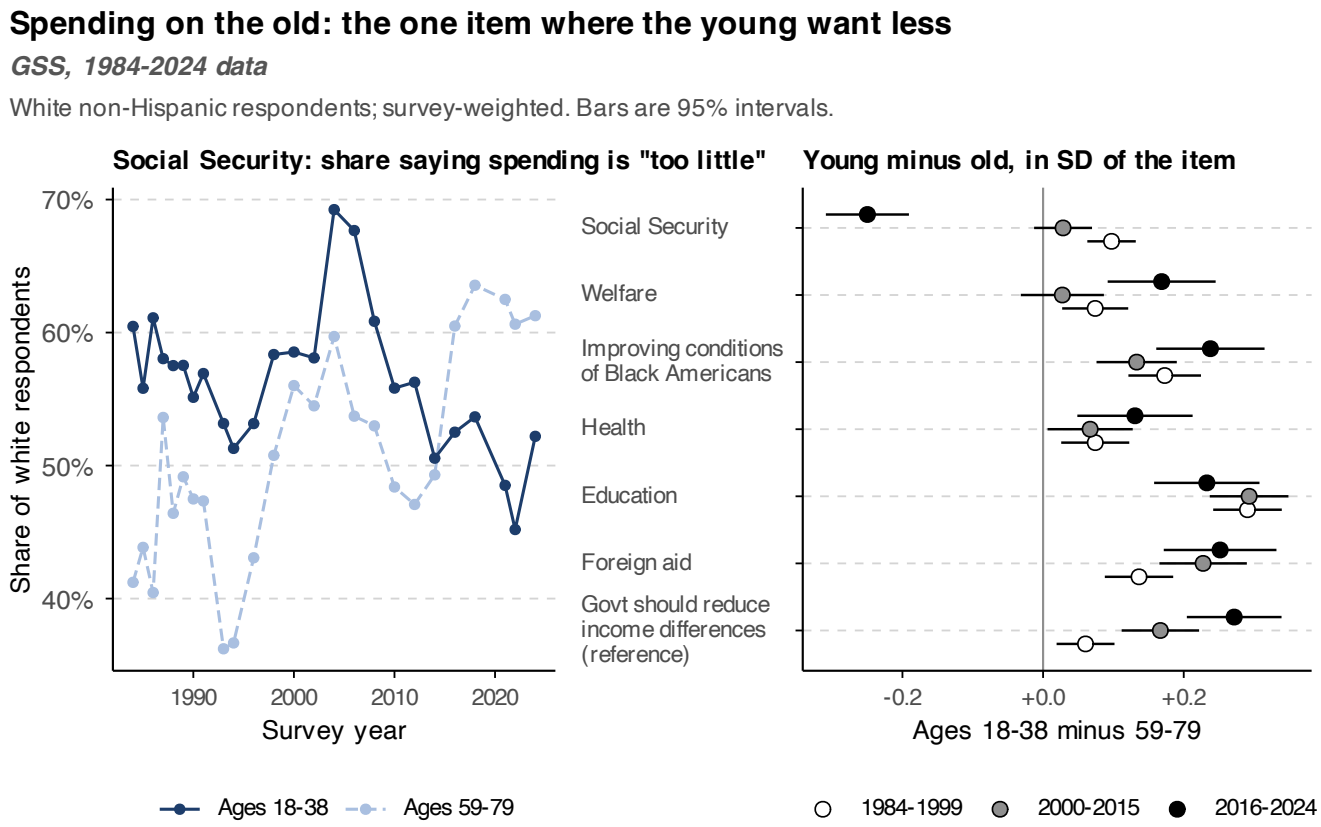


Figure 10: Left: share of white respondents saying Social Security spending is "too little", ages 18–38 and 59–79, by survey year. Right: young–old gap (SD) on each GSS spending item and the redistribution item, by era, 95% intervals

Investigating belief drivers

Preliminary findings

- Inequality, growth, and mobility alone do not explain any of the age gradient in cross-country analysis; the U.S. time series correlation is an outlier.
- Trajectory of older Americans and non-formative-years placebo tests raise doubts about an imprinting story.
- Opposite age gradient on social security, emerging around 2020.
- U.S. has highest perceived age conflict among rich democracies. Recently, the young perceive more conflict than the old.
- No age gap among Black Americans, only White/Hispanic.
- 3/4 of age gap survives within-party; not just higher polarization.

Investigating belief drivers

Why is the US unique? Possibilities:

- Old-age benefits and the political power of the old
- Two-party bundling of cultural and economic positions (majoritarian vs. proportional system)
- Political entrepreneurs (Sanders, Trump)

What explains sharp rise in gap post-2020?

- Prominent billionaires reshaping society (Musk, Bezos)
- Racial justice salience (BLM movement)
- Affordability crisis (inflation, housing) and youth unemployment
- Government debt worries (social security more salient)
- Elderly presidential candidates in 2020 and 2024

Investigating belief drivers

Future analysis

- Second survey wave
  - A more comprehensive questionnaire pairing existing questions with govt. trust, religiosity, and race-related beliefs.
  - In-depth measurement and differentiation of zero-sum/attribution beliefs.
  - An information provision or wording experiment generating exogenous belief variation.
- Geographic and micro variation
  - State and local-level age inequality measures: political representation (L2 voter files), policy tilt, real circumstances (housing, employment, etc.)
- Text analysis
  - Extracting zero-sum rich and zero-sum race narratives from Congressional speeches. Manifesto Project for cross-country.